

Facilitating Participatory Workshops Using Miro

A Narrative Guide for Indian Development Practice

Page 1: Framing the Why – The Role of Miro in Participatory Work

In a field where conversations span across geographies, languages, and lived experiences, tools like Miro have become increasingly central—not for the sake of technology, but for what they enable: participation. Miro is not just a whiteboard, it is a shared thinking space, a place where people—researchers, field workers, community members—can co-create understanding visually, together.

In participatory MEL, HCD, or program design work, we often struggle with power dynamics, silence, over-dominant voices, or simply the inability to “see” what everyone is saying. Miro helps flatten some of that. Participants can move post-its, draw arrows, or group ideas in real time. These simple actions can turn abstract discussions into shared meaning.

But Miro is not magic. It requires framing. It requires prep. And, critically, it requires facilitators to think through access. Many Indian nonprofit teams still struggle with bandwidth or digital fluency. If you’re working with ASHAs or adolescent girls or anganwadi workers, expect hesitancy. That doesn’t mean you don’t use Miro—it means you scaffold it. You prepare it for *them*, not for *you*.

Page 2: Designing the Space – How to Plan a Miro Workshop that Works

A good Miro board is never empty. It breathes with prompts, colors, cues, and clarity. Before any workshop, your job as a facilitator is to design not just a board—but a journey.

Start by asking: what’s the structure of inquiry? Are we mapping a Theory of Change? Tracing a user journey in maternal health systems? Reflecting on what failed in a campaign? Miro thrives when it has zones: defined spaces for specific stages of work.

Color matters. In most participatory sessions, we use: yellow for barriers, green for enablers, blue for ideas, red for gaps. Label frames by activity (“Step 1: Problem Surfacing”) and embed instructions directly on the board.

Roles also matter: lead facilitator, co-facilitator, tech buddy, note-taker, and anchor participants who model engagement. Always have a Plan B. If Miro fails, screen share a backup PDF and gather inputs via chat. What matters is structure, not software.

Page 3: Holding the Room – Facilitation Techniques That Build Participation

The magic of Miro is not in the platform, but in the pause. When participants stop to think, then write, then look up—and realize that someone else across the country just placed a note beside theirs saying the same thing—that’s where meaning emerges.

Start with a warm-up. Ask people to add their name and a proud moment. Then move through your structure: problem surfacing, clustering, assumption tracing, and outcomes mapping. Be flexible with time, but tight with purpose.

Use pauses wisely. A 2-minute silent timer often yields deeper insights than open talk. Watch participation dynamics—some will type in chat instead. Keep energy up with emojis, gentle prompts, and shared annotation moments. The best sessions don’t feel like facilitation. They feel like shared thinking.

Page 4: Aftercare – Cleaning, Synthesizing, and Respecting What Was Shared

Once a Miro board is full, your work isn’t over. In fact, it’s only just begun. The board is not the output—the understanding is.

Group insights under headers. Create a summary frame. Export cleanly: PDF, PNG, or CSV. Use these alongside a synthesis doc or board walkthrough.

And above all: respect what’s shared. Anonymize if needed. Get consent before sharing. Don’t just extract insights—honor them. The board is a trace of a conversation. It deserves care.

Page 5: Cases, Crises, and Confidence – Learning from the Field

Every Miro session is different. In Khunti, fellows mapped anganwadi gaps using arrows and post-its. In Delhi, we ran a youth feedback session with emojis and storyboards. In COVID, we hybridized voice notes and Miro for an adolescent redesign workshop.

Things go wrong. Boards get messy. Internet drops. That’s okay. What matters is a design strong enough to flex. Have a backup plan. Keep notes. Anchor your purpose.

Before any session, ask yourself: Do I understand the board? Do I have support? Am I prepared to listen more than I speak? If yes—you’re ready. Not for a perfect session, but for a meaningful one. That’s enough.